

Herb Van Hagen Real Miner Hustler

By FLIP MORIN
Times Sports Writer

Websters dictionary has the word hustle as meaning "to move or act with vigorous



speech — energetically. Those and other equally action-filled words fill the bill when describing Herb Von Hagen — or Berbie Hustle.

Von Hagen, left fielder for the University of Texas at El Paso baseball team, drew the nickname from Coach Andy Cohen when it was learned Von Hagen's hometown of Hamilton, Ohio is near Cincinnati.

Not quite clear?

Well Pete Rose, who plays for the Cincinnati Reds, is nicknamed "Charlie Hustle." So with the proximity of the two cities, the obvious thing is to name other baseball players of equally determined stature, something similar.

"Herbie Hustle" wasn't always the mainstay he currently enjoys on the roster in his senior year.

As a matter of fact he's probably more remembered from the 1973 season when "hustle" wasn't one of his better sides. Von Hagen led the Miners in strikeouts that year with 40, tops in the all-time category of most times struck out. That's "Horrendous Herbie."

But he made up for that shabby showing by tying Glen Villarreal and Tim Peden with most doubles at five. This year

he's the No. 2 man with 10 two-baggers, right behind Bob Downing who has collected 11.

Von Hagen, 6-foot and 185 pounds, was an all-around athlete in his high school years, but liked baseball most of all, enough to garner three varsity letters at Hamilton. He also lettered three years in football, two in basketball, and played softball and track.

Although he prefers catching, he's been known to pitch, play shortstop and now occupies left field for the Miners. He played a couple of years of short for Cochise Junior College in Douglas, Ariz., where Coach Andy Cohen got wind of him. Cochise had a good season those years, narrowly losing to Mesa JC, the team which eventually won the nationals.

SAME ABILITY

Although he hadn't in mind tabbing Von Hagen with the "hustle" moniker right off, Cohen soon saw quite a ball player in the versatile athlete.

"He's the type of ball player any coach wants to have around," Cohen said. "He plays shortstop, pitches, catches and has desire."

When Von Hagen came to U. T. El Paso in 1972 on a scholarship, he started at short, was moved to center

field, but was soon sidelined with a pulled groin muscle.

Things didn't look bright for Von Hagen and visions of his "hustle" nickname being changed to "Hurting Herbie" flashed across his mind.

COMEBACK

But he came back quickly but found himself in left field. Joe Pennies doing such a commendable job in center made sure of that.

"It's really a nice feeling to know someone the caliber of Herb is with you in the outfield," Pennies points out. "He's a good helper, always show hustle and spirit, regardless of whether we're ahead or down."

Von Hagen now admits he likes the left field spot where there's plenty of action, especially when the big hitters come around.

For his nickname, Von Hagen continually amazes the fans with one-handed leaping catches alongside the fence or with his back to the wall. He's speared many a potential inside-the-park homer with high

leaps or by flashing speed.

"He's what we call an adventurous baseball player," Cohen notes. "He'll try most anything, slides hard, runs hard and has an A-plus throwing arm."

His left field coverage drew high praise from better than college mentors recently when Dave Garcia, manager of the El Paso Diblos congratulated Von Hagen following the Diblo-Miner exhibition game at Dudley Field. Von Hagen gloved several super shots off Diablo bats, and it got him a hand shake and words of encouragement after the game.

Pennies noted it was comfortable in center to know Von Hagen was alongside him and that oft-times you don't even have to back him up.

Von Hagen likes to predict things like his hitting, and he's 75 per cent correct this year, but the lead-off man is presently in a hitting slump, from .375 to .308.

Well, who wants to be known as "The Hustling Hard Hitter Herbie" Von Hagen, anyhow?

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